WOMEN in EdTech

A holistic approach to Education



Accessible and affordable education is an indicator of growth and development. During the COVID19 pandemic, among the many sectors that took a hit, education ranked high. It was thrown into chaos with the onset of online classrooms and zoom calls. Student and teacher interfaces from the physical classroom quickly changed to brick boxes on the screen in March 2020. With this change came the challenge of a constant need to adapt to new technology. There were training sessions for teachers, for students, new buttons to press, and revised benchmarks to follow. This was done to create a sustainable educational environment that could substantially replace an offline classroom system.

Throughout history, women have been active majority participants in the education system of India, specifically at the school level. Through generations, women have taken up roles as teachers, mentors, and school principals accelerating the growth of the education sector. An education sector, already brimming with multiple possibilities came up during the time. This was slowly making its place as an alternative and in many cases a supportive system to the existing education industry.

This was the EdTech or Education Technology interface. EdTech entered Indian markets around the 2010s. Companies like Educomp, smart classrooms forayed into this new sector. While Education support companies like Byju's, Extramarks, Whitehat Jr, Coursera, Udemy, Edx, Khan Academy, Google classroom, and Unacademy have developed and grown over the last 10 years (Some of these now having been acquired by others), it was precisely through the years of the pandemic that a sudden boost in their popularity began. Today India ranks second on the global scale as the fastest-growing EdTech industry in the nation. With the pandemic, this industry saw an obvious boom thanks to the need for space-less learning experiences, and women found for them a fertile ground to propel this industry further.

So then, what is EdTech? When and how did it grow into a tangible education sector in India and how has it proven to be a nesting ground for women in leadership roles? It is an interesting trajectory.

When IT tools are introduced into the classroom framework, it helps create better engagements within the teacher-student interface. While technology is used to aid the physical space of the classroom, it has now grown into alternative databases of knowledge through courses offered to anyone and everyone as a way to not only add to the learning experience of primary and higher education students but also for working professionals and less privileged people who are otherwise not able to afford specialized education. The flexibility provided by EdTech companies has enabled more women to pursue careers in this sector. They work from the confines of their homes creating a comfortable space for their development.

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The sprouting of many EdTech companies in India in the past two years has prompted a much more diverse and wide range of